



Genuine threat: Portugal has a team capable of scoring four or five goals on any given day, as well as defending against an opponent's late pushes in a close game. GETTY IMAGES

Leão wide on the left is the only permanent positional duty, so expect a fairly flexible approach from Martínez's starting lineup. Portugal's central midfield role is undecided. There are a few options: Bernardo Silva moving back from attack, Otávio playing a more box-to-box role, opening a chance to young Joao Neves, or using Ruben Neves alongside another midfielder for a more defensive setup.

Its defence, though, is more settled. Diogo Costa will likely start in goal, with Ruben Dias and Pepe in the centre of defence. The fullback positions are more flexible, allowing the coach to choose players based on the opponent and fatigue levels.

Consistent returns

Meanwhile, making its eighth consecutive Euro appearance, Czechia is placed 36th in the current

men's FIFA rankings. Having reached the quarterfinals in the last two editions, the Lokomotiva will look to advance further this time around.

For the first time since 2018, the Czechs will have a new coach, Ivan Hasek. Jaroslav Silhavy departed from the position in November last year, having led the team for five years and 56 games.

Silhavy oversaw much of the Czech Republic's qualification campaign, putting them in unfamiliar territory coming into the tournament. The previous head coach led them to four victories and one defeat in eight qualifiers, finishing second in Group E, level on points with top-ranked Albania, and qualifying for the group stages.

Unknowns look to make a mark

The other team in the group, Turkey, topped a qualifying group with Croatia and Wales in it. However, it lost 1-0 to Hungary and 6-1 to Austria in friendlies in March. Its squad is certainly an unknown quantity heading into the summer. There's a lot of talent in this team, but how it comes together is a question waiting to be answered.

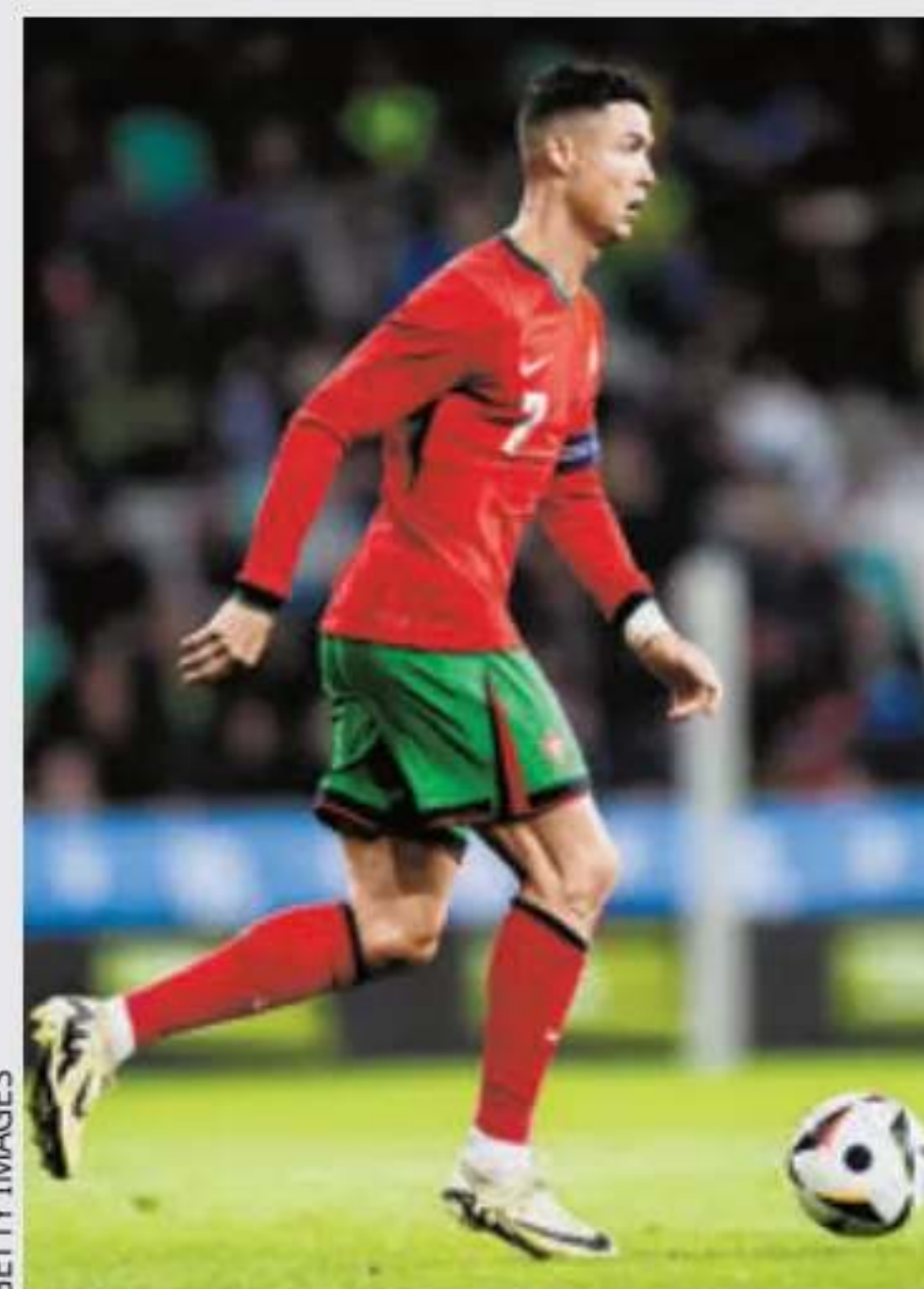
It reached its third consecutive Euro finals after posting a 4-0 victory at home to Latvia on October 15. It was unable to go past the group stages in its previous two appearances but memorably made it to the semifinals in 2008, where it lost 3-2 to Germany in a thriller.

Georgia made history during the Euro qualifying rounds and reached a major football tournament for the first time. This was the eighth time it attempted to qualify for the tournament as an independent nation. The team will be skippered by Napoli forward Khvicha Kvaratskhelia and will look to spring surprises in the tournament.

Knockouts predictions:

Besides clear favourite Portugal, one can expect a tight contest between Czechia and Turkey. Both sides have a similar record in 2024, but Vincenzo Montella's Turkey, brimming with bright talents, has the potential to take the cake.

PLAYERS TO WATCH OUT FOR



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CRISTIANO RONALDO

Cristiano Ronaldo needs no introduction. Even at the age of 39, his name is still synonymous with top-of-the-line football. The former Real Madrid and Juventus star is making waves in the Saudi Pro League (SPL). Ronaldo has scored 64 goals in 69 games for Al-Nassr in all competitions since joining on a free transfer in January 2023 after leaving Manchester United. He recently broke the SPL record for most goals (35) in a season.



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KENAN YILDIZ

Representing Turkey, Kenan Yildiz brings his talents to the international arena from his club career at Juventus. Despite being a newcomer with only three caps for the senior team, where he scored just once, Yildiz's performance as a second striker has been noteworthy.